

Circaetus pectoralis

Black-chested snake eagle



Location E. to southern Africa

Length 26 in (65 cm)
Weight 2¼–5½ lb (1–2.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Least concern



A specialized hunter of reptiles, the black-chested snake eagle has tightly meshed scales on its legs and toes that protect it from biting snakes. It has a large head with large, yellow eyes. The bird has strong legs and small feet, and is bare of feathers. It is often found soaring over open hill slopes as it searches for prey, and will occasionally hover. It feeds primarily on snakes—usually avoiding poisonous ones—but will also take lizards, birds, bats, and even fish. The female lays one egg and incubates it for 48 days. Both parents care for the young; once fledged, the young is dependent for up to 6 months.

Terathopius ecaudatus

Bateleur



Location Africa (south of Sahara)

Length 23½ in (60 cm)
Weight 4½–6½ lb (2–3 kg)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Near threatened



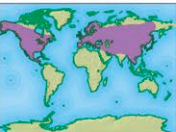
The bateleur is a colorful eagle with a chestnut-red mantle on its back, a black body and head, and a bare, red or orange face. Females have gray

shoulders and black-edged, white secondary flight feathers; males have black secondaries. The long, pointed, almost falconlike wings and the short tail make this bird unmistakable in flight—it tilts from side to side like a tightrope walker trying to balance. The bateleur is mainly a scavenger, but will also take small mammals, birds, reptiles, fish, eggs, and insects. Groups of these eagles may gather at termite mounds when the insects fly from their nests to breed. During courtship, the bird displays a rocking and rolling flight, almost stopping in midair with the wings held open. It builds its large stick nest in an open-branched tree.



Circus hudsonius

Hen harrier



Location North America to N. Central America, Europe, Asia

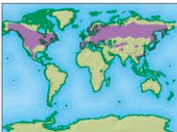
Length 17–20 ½ in (43–52 cm)
Weight 13–19 oz (350–525 g)
Plumage Sexes differ
Migration Migrant
Status Least concern



Instead of soaring, the hen harrier flies close to the ground with its wings held in a shallow “V.” It has keen eyesight and good hearing, which it uses to locate small animals hidden in vegetation. The female (shown above) is larger than the male, and is brown, with a white rump, whereas the male is gray. Unusually for a bird of prey, the hen harrier nests on the ground, making a nest of sticks and grass.

Accipiter gentilis

Northern goshawk



Location Canada to Mexico, Europe, Asia

Length 19–28 in (48–70 cm)
Weight 2¼–3¼ lb (1–1.5 kg)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern

A high-speed hunter of woods and forests, the northern goshawk varies considerably across its very wide range. Asian birds are usually pale, while North American ones often have dark heads. Females are always larger than males—sometimes weighing up to half as much again—and young birds are brown, eventually turning gray.



Northern goshawks feed on birds up to the size of crows and pigeons, and mammals up to the size of small hares. They often hunt from a perched position at the forest edge, and are shaped for pursuit at close quarters, with short, rounded wings, and a long tail that is used for steering and braking. Apart from these sudden sorties after their prey, they are secretive, and often go unseen. When courting, prospective partners call loudly as they soar into the air, and once their nest is built, they are extremely territorial, driving any intruding birds away. In cold winters, when food is scarce, they are sometimes found well to the south of their normal range.

Buteo buteo

Common buzzard



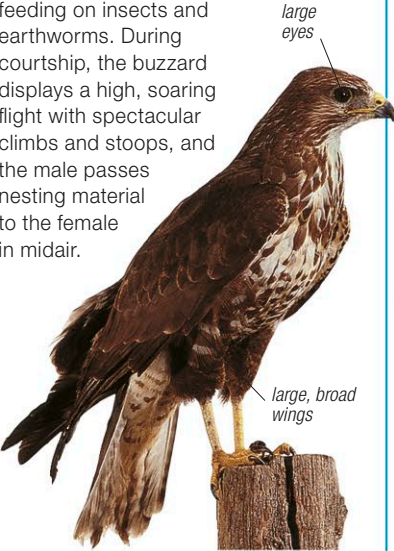
Location Europe, Asia, N. and E. to southern Africa

Length 20–22½ in (50–57 cm)
Weight 19–36 oz (525–1,000 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Partial migrant
Status Least concern



This medium-sized raptor, known as the common buzzard, has large, broad wings and a shortish tail, and is built for soaring on thermals. It is very variable in color. Although large, the common buzzard catches relatively small prey, such as voles, mice, and insects. It is often seen on the

ground, especially in winter, feeding on insects and earthworms. During courtship, the buzzard displays a high, soaring flight with spectacular climbs and stoops, and the male passes nesting material to the female in midair.



Buteo galapagoensis

Galapagos hawk



Location Galapagos Islands

Length 22 in (55 cm)
Weight 23–30 oz (650–850 g)
Plumage Sexes alike
Migration Nonmigrant
Status Vulnerable



This is the only diurnal bird of prey on the Galapagos Islands. It is also one of the few bird species that have cooperative breeding habits—females that have extra males helping them are more successful in producing young. The Galapagos hawk is sooty brown all over, with a gray-barred tail. The

female is considerably larger than the male. This hawk hunts mainly from the air, gliding in to take prey, but can also hover. It feeds on small mammals, birds, reptiles, and insects. Both parents care for the young—usually one—and will allow it to remain close for up to 4 months before driving it away.

